

Map your Mind

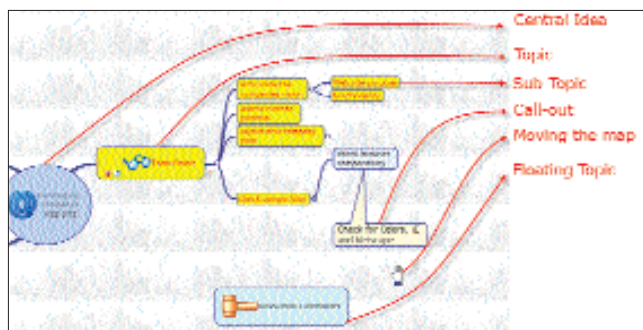
Think your thoughts are adrift? Here's how you chart ramblings to plan, organise and execute

Planning, strategy and venom—your boss's favourite topics when a project goes asunder. So, you sit down all over again to plot and plan. You'd like to fly off to Ibiza; instead, you fly helter-skelter with strategies on your mind. "Do whatever it takes to stimulate that pea-sized brain of yours," he growls. Then you remind yourself of taking into account outcomes that just might not be savoury. Oh damn, your thought process is complication personified! Well, you need to sit back, organise and structure it out.

Mind mapping is a technique that organises your thoughts in a representative way using words, symbols and pictures, and goes a step further by letting you manage all the content associated with these thoughts. It works on the principle that the eyes and the brain focus on the central image on the screen or a paper. This central image is the main idea of the thought process in mind mapping. From this central image, arise branches, representing the main themes that relate to the central idea. These have sub-branches that go to many levels, making a tree-like structure. Thus, a mind map is a flexible, pleasing, easy-to-understand and easy-to-memorise document.

Creating your first mind map

Though there are numerous tools to create mind maps, we will focus on Mindjet's MindManager. The reason? It's one of the best. Install the latest version—MindManager X5—from our Mindware CD or download it from www.mindjet.com.



The structure of a typical mind map looks something like this

The interface is quite intuitive and similar to that of Microsoft Office products. Placed just below the Menu bar, the Toolbar has buttons for common functions such as Save, Edit, etc. Move your mouse pointer over the button and a balloon tip displays its function, and its keyboard shortcut. Below the toolbar lies the Action Bar that has buttons such as Map View and Outline View, to switch between different map views. Use buttons such as Brainstorm, Review and Presentation to switch between different modes.

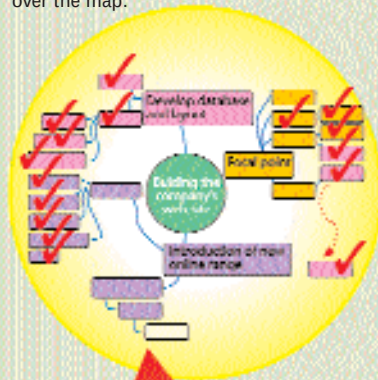
Change fonts, colours, line types and shapes in the map using the formatting toolbar that's, by default, placed at the bottom. The export toolbar, also placed there, allows for integration of MindManager with Microsoft Office. To the right are icons for the task pane that let you access Library, Search, etc., while you work on a map.

To chart a basic map, fundamental elements needed are the Central Topic, Main Topics, Sub-Topics, Floating Topics and Callouts. The first three elements form the tree-like structure of the map. Floating topics are not attached to any branch, and callouts are used for comments. Create a blank map (**File > New > Blank Map**), click 'Central Topic', enter the title of your map and press [Enter]. Press [Enter] once more to key in the main topic, and hit [Enter] again. Sounds confusing? Here are two rules to dissipate those baffling mists—Rule 1: Press [Enter] after typing any text; Rule 2: Select any particular topic, and press [Enter]. Voila! You have a topic at the same level as the one that was selected. To create a topic at a lower level, you need to press [Insert].

Click on empty space, and type to create a floating topic. Mouse-clicks are a little tricky in MindManager—click and hold the left mouse button down to change the mouse pointer to a hand that you can use to drag

Step 5: Project completed

Now your Mind Map is ready to be used to track progress. When individual tasks are completed, you can put an icon to show so. When all the tasks are completed, you will see checkmarks all over the map.



Step 4: Further planning

Now look at the tree carefully, and delete the unwanted ideas, finalise the tasks and allot them to people in your team. On each task, you can enter information such as the date when the task was allotted and the person in charge of it. You can update this information at will.

